

be introduced into the ear in earache." Apart from its medicinal uses, chickweed is a tasty and nutritious vegetable.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Chickweed is chiefly used to treat irritated skin, being applied as juice, poultice, ointment, or cream. In certain cases, chickweed may soothe severe itchiness where all other remedies have failed. It is often used to relieve eczema, varicose ulcers, and nettle rash (hives). An infusion of the fresh or dried plant may be added to a bath, where the herb's emollient properties will help to reduce inflammation—in rheumatic joints, for example—and encourage tissue repair. Chickweed may also be taken internally to treat chest ailments. There is some suggestion that chickweed has an antiobesity action.

Cautions If taken in excessive doses, chickweed may cause diarrhea and vomiting. Do not take during pregnancy.

Self-help Uses Eczema, p. 300; Diaper rash & inflamed skin rashes, p. 318; Nettle rash, p. 303.

Stillingia sylvatica (Euphorbiaceae) Queen's Delight

Description Perennial growing to 1.2 m (4 ft). Has leathery leaves, yellow flowers without petals, and 3-lobed fruit.

Habitat & Cultivation Queen's delight is native to the southeastern U.S., where it prefers sandy soils. The root is unearthed in autumn.

Part Used Root.

Constituents Queen's delight contains diterpenes, fixed oil, volatile oil, resin, and tannins. The fresh root is considered to be most active.

History & Folklore Queen's delight was used by Native Americans as a purgative, a treatment for skin eruptions, and a remedy for venereal disease. Creek women who had just given birth took a decoction of the root or were bathed with an infusion. Queen's delight was included in the *Pharmacopoeia of the United States* from 1831 to 1926.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Queen's delight appears to promote general detoxification. It is taken internally to help clear constipation, boils, weeping eczema, and scrofula (tubercular infection of the lymph glands of the neck). The root is also taken to treat bronchitis and throat infection. Externally, it is applied as a lotion to hemorrhoids, eczema, and psoriasis.

⚠ Cautions Use only under professional supervision. Queen's delight is emetic and purgative in large doses.



Nux vomica is used in homeopathic preparations.

Strychnos nux-vomica (Loganiaceae) Nux Vomica

Description Evergreen tree growing to 49 ft (15 m). Has glossy oval leaves, tubular white flowers, and yellow fruit containing 5–8 disk-shaped seeds.

Habitat & Cultivation Nux vomica is native to Southeast Asia. It grows wild and is cultivated commercially. The seeds are gathered when mature.

Parts Used Seeds.

Constituents Nux vomica contains 3% indole alkaloids (predominantly strychnine, with many others), loganin, chlorgenic acid, and fixed oil. Strychnine is a lethal poison, producing intense muscle spasms.

History & Folklore Nux vomica seeds were first brought to Europe in the 15th century, probably as a poison for game and rodents. In 1640, the seeds were first used in European medicine, as a stimulant.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Though rarely used internally due to its toxicity, nux vomica can be an effective nervous system stimulant, particularly in the elderly. In Chinese herbal medicine the seeds are used externally to relieve pain, to treat various types of tumors, and to relieve paralysis, including Bell's palsy (facial paralysis). Nux vomica is a common homeopathic remedy prescribed mainly for digestive problems, sensitivity to cold, irritability, and melancholia.



Research In a Chinese clinical trial, a paste made from nux vomica seeds was applied to 15,000 patients with Bell's palsy. The treatment was reported to have been effective in more than 80% of the cases.

Related Species Many *Strychnos* species are equally potent and have been used as arrow poisons.

⚠ Cautions Take nux vomica only in homeopathic preparations. This herb and strychnine are subject to legal restrictions in most countries.

Styrax benzoin (Styraceae) Benzoin Gum

Description Shrubby deciduous tree growing to 30 ft (9 m). Has pointed oval leaves and clusters of white, fragrant, bell-shaped flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Southeast Asia, benzoin grows in tropical rainforests. It is also cultivated for its gum, which exudes from incisions made in the bark of trees that are at least 7 years old.

Part Used Gum.

Constituents Benzoin gum contains variable quantities of cinnamic, benzoic, and sumaresinolic acid esters, free acids (such as benzoic acid), benzaldehyde, and vanillin.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Benzoin gum is strongly antiseptic and astringent. It may be used externally on wounds and ulcers to tighten and disinfect the affected tissue. When taken internally, benzoin gum acts to settle cramping, to stimulate coughing, and to disinfect the urinary tract. Benzoin gum is an ingredient of Friar's Balsam, an antiseptic and expectorant steam inhalation for sore throats, head and chest colds, asthma, and bronchitis.

Swertia chirata (Gentianaceae) Chiretta, Chirayata (Hindi)

Description Annual, growing to about 3 ft (1 m), with a much-branched stem, smooth, pointed, lance-shaped leaves, and numerous purple-tinged, pale green flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Chiretta grows at high altitudes in northern India and Nepal. The whole herb is harvested while in flower.

Parts Used Whole herb.

Constituents Chiretta contains xanthenes, bitter iridoids (including amarogentin), alkaloids, and flavones.

History & Folklore Chiretta was a common treatment for malaria, until Peruvian bark (*Cinchona* spp., p. 83) became readily available in Europe and Asia.